audiences in the Global South (McDowell et al. 2024). For example, recent calls for greater inclusivity in IO leadership, including at the World Bank and IMF, have aimed to address these concerns. Furthermore, IOs could engage directly with local communities and governments in program design, procurement, and implementation, demonstrating sensitivity to local needs and perspectives. This approach aligns with the localization movement in foreign aid, which emphasizes empowering local actors in decision-making processes.

Transparency and accountability are equally critical. By reducing the opacity of their decision-making processes, IOs can foster trust among member states, making countries feel more included and valued. Reforms aimed at improving efficiency, accountability, and responsiveness to members' concerns have already been initiated by institutions like the World Bank and the IMF. The EU, in response to populist critiques, has also made efforts to modify its immigration policies, demonstrating an ability to adapt to member states' evolving needs.

Another strategy IOs can employ is to tightly integrate the benefits they offer, making the cost of withdrawal prohibitively high. For example, the EU's single market, customs union, and eurozone have created deep economic interdependence among member states. Even during the eurocrisis, when Greece considered leaving the EU, the economic and logistical challenges of de-integration made remaining in the union the more viable option. Similarly, the protracted and costly Brexit negotiations served as a cautionary tale for other populist leaders contemplating a rollback of European integration.

Ultimately, IOs must balance structural reforms with proactive engagement in order to address the challenges posed by populism. By tackling long-standing grievances, enhancing inclusivity and transparency, and demonstrating their tangible benefits, IOs can strengthen their resilience and ensure their continued relevance.

RETRENCHMENT

IOs can strategically scale back their operations as a preemptive measure to minimize vulnerabilities in the face of populist challenges. By narrowing their focus to core issues, steering clear of polarizing areas, and respecting